Nike Partnership Strategy

Girls Flag Football — Brand Deal Playbook

Date: 2026-02-19 | **Prepared by:** TPM Agent **Classification:** Confidential — Client Eyes Only

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Executive Summary

A first-year Nike sponsorship for a new girls flag football organization is realistic but **must be earned, not assumed.** Nike is the most sought-after youth sports partner in the world. They receive thousands of partnership requests per year and say no to nearly all of them.

The realistic path: Build 100+ registered players and one season of documented impact first. Enter through NFL Flag's Nike relationship rather than cold outreach. Lead with product, not cash. Nike's Year 1 deal will likely be $25K–$75K in product value with a structured path to a $250K–$500K+ relationship in Years 2–3 as national scale is demonstrated.

This is a multi-stage negotiation that begins immediately with positioning work, not outreach.

Why Nike Will Say Yes — The Alignment Case

Nike's stated priorities for community and grassroots sports partnerships:

Nike Priority	Our Alignment
Girls in Sport	Girls-only flag football program — exact match
Underserved communities	School district partnerships in underserved AZ zip codes
Emerging sports growth	Flag football is the fastest-growing youth sport in the US
NFL partnership halo	NFL Flag affiliation + AZ Cardinals co-branding
Title IX advocacy	Directly expands girls' access to organized football
Content and storytelling	Built-in content engine: girls playing, competing, winning
Social media culture	TikTok-native audience, authentic moments, viral potential
National scalability	AZ proof of concept → TX, CA, FL expansion

Nike does not sponsor programs. Nike sponsors **movements and moments.** Build the movement first.

The Three Entry Points

Entry Point A: NFL Flag → Nike (HIGHEST PRIORITY)

Why: NFL Flag is co-branded with Nike. The NFL's official uniform contract is with Nike. NFL Flag Arizona chapter directors have access to Nike contacts through this relationship.

How to execute:

1. Secure NFL Flag girls chapter affiliation (see Phase 1)

2. Ask your NFL Flag regional coordinator: "Can you introduce us to the Nike rep who works with NFL Flag in our region?"
3. This warm introduction bypasses the cold outreach problem entirely
4. Your pitch: "We're the NFL Flag girls chapter in AZ. We want to build out the Nike gear story for our players."

Timeline: Can begin outreach after NFL Flag affiliation confirmed (Target: May 2026)

Entry Point B: Nike Community Impact Fund

Why: Nike has a formal grant program for community sports organizations. A 501(c)(3) status + girls' sports alignment + school district partnerships is a very competitive application.

How to execute:

1. Confirm 501(c)(3) status is active (required for grant eligibility)
2. Monitor Nike Community Impact Fund application windows (typically opens 1–2x per year)
3. Submit full application with impact metrics, photos, program description
4. Application requirements typically include: IRS determination letter, program description, budget, expected outcomes, demographics served

Realistic outcome: $10,000–$50,000 grant (product and/or cash) **Timeline:** Apply as soon as 501(c)(3) confirmed and first season data is available

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Entry Point C: Nike AZ Territory Manager

Why: Nike assigns territory managers to handle regional community and grassroots partnerships. These are lower-tier deals but faster to close than national programs.

How to find them:

- Ask Arizona Cardinals community team for introduction (Cardinals have Nike relationship as NFL team)
- Ask local Nike flagship store (AZ Mills or Scottsdale Fashion Square) — they have territory rep contact
- LinkedIn search: "Nike territory manager Arizona" or "Nike community relations Arizona"

What to say in first contact:

> *"I'm the founder of [Organization], a girls flag football program in Arizona. We have [X] registered players and partnerships with [X] school districts. We're affiliated with NFL Flag and the Arizona Cardinals. I'd love 20 minutes to show you what we're building and explore how Nike can be a part of it."*

Timeline: Begin after first showcase game with media coverage (Target: August 2026)

The Sponsorship Ask — Tiered Structure

Tier 1: Community Product Partner (Year 1 Minimum)

Ask when: 50–100 players, first season underway, no media yet

Element	Ask
Product value	$25,000–$50,000

Product type	Game jerseys (Nike Dri-FIT), training shorts, cleats (select styles), game balls
Logo placement	Nike logo on all game jerseys + website sponsor section
Content rights	Nike may use any photos/video we produce of players wearing Nike gear
Duration	1 year with annual renewal option
Cash	$0 (do not lead with cash in Tier 1)

Why this works for Nike: Ultra-low risk. They donate wholesale-cost product (worth ~$5K–$10K to them). In return they get 50–100 girls in Nike gear with content rights. This is a marketing spend, not a charity donation.

Tier 2: Official Presenting Sponsor (Year 1 Preferred)

Ask when: 100+ players, first game played, media coverage secured, Cardinals co-brand confirmed

Element	Ask
Product value	$50,000–$75,000
Cash	$25,000–$50,000
Title	"Girls Flag Football [AZ Organization Name], presented by Nike"
Exclusivity	Category exclusivity: footwear and apparel (no UA, Adidas, etc.)
Event naming	"[Organization] Nike Championship Cup" for season finale
Social media	Minimum 4 Nike co-tagged posts per season
Athlete ambassador	1 local female athlete/coach as Nike ambassador for the program
Content rights	Full commercial rights to all player/game content produced
Duration	1 year + year 2 escalation option (if national reg hits 500, deal doubles)

Why this works for Nike: They get category exclusivity on a growing brand. The Title IX story + NFL halo + girls' sports narrative is exactly what Nike's marketing team needs for their content calendar.

Tier 3: National Growth Partner (Year 2–3)

Triggered when: 1,000 registered girls national, 3 states active, strong media presence

Element	Ask
Cash	$250,000–$500,000/year
Product	$100,000/year all-in gear allotment
Marketing support	Nike athlete ambassador (national profile)
Co-marketing budget	$50,000 Nike co-branded national campaign
Naming	National championship event

Duration	3-year deal

This is the deal that transforms the organization from a program to a national brand.

Negotiation Playbook

What Nike Will Push Back On

1. **Cash:** They will want to do product-only first. Accept this for Year 1. Write Year 2 cash escalation into the contract.
2. **Exclusivity ask:** They will want it for free. Require minimum product threshold to grant exclusivity.
3. **Content rights scope:** They will want broad rights. Protect: player names/likenesses, school district rights, any underage player content must require individual parent release.
4. **Term length:** They will want 1 year with no commitments. Push for 1 year + 2-year option with escalation triggers.

Power Moves Before the Meeting

- **Have Under Armour talking:** Even exploratory emails with UA create genuine urgency. You don't need a UA deal — you need Nike to know they could lose exclusivity.
- **Show the Cardinals letter:** Any formal engagement letter from Arizona Cardinals elevates your legitimacy instantly. Nike respects NFL relationships.
- **Bring the highlight reel:** Open the meeting with 60 seconds of your best game footage. No slides until they've seen the girls play.
- **Lead with the national vision:** Nike does not sign AZ-only programs. They sign programs that will be national in 3 years. Open with the expansion map.
- **Know their comps:** Nike sponsors NFL Flag nationally. Your program is their girls channel. Position as complementary, not competitive.

Non-Negotiables (Do Not Give Away)

- Do not grant exclusivity without minimum product value threshold ($25K minimum)
- Do not allow Nike to use images of individual underage players without signed parent release forms included in the contract
- Do not sign a deal that limits your ability to accept grants from non-apparel sponsors (Nike should only restrict apparel/footwear category)
- Always retain right to end relationship if Nike's brand becomes controversy-adjacent

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Alternate / Backup Sponsors (Build Simultaneously)

Do not put all partnership eggs in the Nike basket. Build a parallel sponsor pipeline so you have alternatives and leverage.

Brand	Tier	Category	Why Viable
Under Armour	National	Apparel/footwear	Strong women's sports commitment, challenger brand wants to beat Nike
Adidas	National	Apparel/footwear	Growing girls' sports portfolio, less Nike competition

Gatorade / PepsiCo	National	Hydration	Standard youth sports sponsor, easy yes for product deal
Banner Health / Dignity Health	Regional (AZ)	Healthcare	Youth sports + safety story, strong AZ presence
State Farm	National	Insurance	Major youth sports sponsor, girls' sports alignment
AZ corporate brands (Fry's, Shamrock Foods, etc.)	Local	General	Easiest to close, builds credibility for national pitch
Women's Sports Foundation	Grant	General	Not a sponsor but $25K–$100K grants available
NFL Foundation	Grant	Football	Youth football development grants, $10K–$50K range
Title IX-aligned foundations	Grant	General	Multiple available — research AAUW, Ms. Foundation, etc.

Strategy: Close 1–2 local AZ deals before approaching Nike. Show Nike you're already being invested in locally. It signals momentum and reduces their perceived risk.

Nike Deal Timeline

Milestone	Target Date	Gate
NFL Flag affiliation confirmed	May 2026	Entry Point A unlocked
AZ Cardinals engagement letter	May 2026	Credibility builder
First season showcase game + media	August 2026	Proof of traction
Nike pitch deck finalized	August 15, 2026	Deck ready before outreach
Nike entry point contacted	September 1, 2026	Begin relationship
Nike first meeting held	October 15, 2026	Pitch delivered
Nike term sheet received	November 15, 2026	Negotiation begins
Nike deal signed	November 30, 2026	Year 1 deal executed
Nike gear delivered	January 2027	Season 2 opens with Nike

What a Realistic Year 1 Nike Deal Looks Like

Most likely outcome: Product-only deal, $25,000–$50,000 retail value in Nike Dri-FIT uniforms, training gear, and select footwear. Nike logo on uniforms. Content rights granted. 1-year term with renewal option.

Best case outcome: $50,000 product + $25,000 cash. Official presenting sponsor title. Social media co-marketing. 1-year deal with written option to double if national registration hits 500.

Worst case outcome: Nike Community Impact Grant — $10,000–$25,000 one-time product grant. No formal sponsorship relationship yet. Use this to build the ongoing relationship.

The real prize of a Year 1 Nike deal is not the money. It is the Nike swoosh on your jersey. That logo changes the entire value proposition for every other sponsor, every school district partnership conversation, every media story, and every player recruitment conversation. One Nike logo unlocks the next five deals.

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